> **The Chinese are the main competition in my event**

ing a berth for India at the Paris Olympics.

Now training for the Asian Games, his day comprises 4–5 hours of shooting practice in the morning and a planned workout in the evening.

Where does he expect the competition to come from? "The Chinese are the main competition," he says. Rudrankksh's idol, like of most shooters his generation, is Abhinav Bindra, who won the first individual Olympic medal for India. He trains with a Walther rifle and spends his spare time doing research on his sport. "Rudrankksh has always been interested in mechanics and knows his weapon inside out. He can disassemble and assemble it quickly," says Balasaheb.

What sets him apart from the others? "Rudrankksh has a champion's mindset. He also has the ability to dig into his reserves in crisis situations. He is very hard-working, and pays great attention to detail," says Suma Shirur, former shooter and chief coach of the 10-metre air rifle event.

–Rahul Noronha

it's a worthy investment. In 2021, after winning gold at Khelo India, she earned a scholarship, which has come in handy. "With Khelo India, I'm getting some help with travelling expenses and equipment too," she says.

A student of science at the Lal Bahadur Shashtri Mahavidyalaya, Aditi divides her time between archery and studies. As the "kid" of India's impressive compound archery contingent, Aditi gets to play with one of her idols, world #2 Jyothi Sukhi Vennam, who will also be one of her toughest rivals. She is understandably nervous about the Games, for unlike other competitions, this time, all eyes will be on her. "If we repeat the performance at the World Championship and World Cup, then we will most definitely win the gold medal and make India proud," she says. If Aditi does accomplish goal #3, first on her to-do list is to show her medal to 'Sir' and 'Papa' and then take a trip to the Pandharpur Temple.

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> **If we repeat the performance at the World Championship and World Cup, we will most definitely win gold and make India proud**

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» JESWIN ALDRIN, 21
LONG JUMP

When Jeswin Aldrin, then 17, arrived from Mudalur in Tamil Nadu to the Inspire Institute of Sport (IIS) in Vijayanagar in Karnataka, he felt like one of his favourite manga characters—Luffy from *One Piece*. "His goal is to be more free and do whatever you want," he says. At the IIS, there was no mom or dad to monitor how much time he spent watching anime. He finally got a mobile; he could play PUBG and watch films. "In my home, it used to be very strict. I was happy being here," he says. That's not to say he has a free rein at IIS. It's because of his disciplined regimen that he has emerged as one of India's brightest prospects in the long jump.

> **My main focus will be to not get injured, stay healthy and train well**

In 2023, apart from making the final 12 in the World Athletic Championships in Budapest, Aldrin won silver at the Asian Indoor Championships with a new national indoor record. He also jumped 8.42 m at the National Jumps Competition at Bellary in March to beat the national record of his compatriot Murali Sreeshankar. He attributes the marked improvement to a change in the "overall mentality compared to last season". "Everything has improved—focus, technique, power and speed," he adds. On his rivalry with Sreeshankar, who will also be a top contender at the Games, he says, "We both want to be the best and push each other a lot."

Aldrin comes from a family of sweetshop owners. In his childhood, time spent playing sports wasn't deemed worthwhile. Aldrin credits his uncle Simon Isaac and former coach Antony Yaich for encouraging his passion and convincing his parents to do the same.

Long jump, like javelin throw, is emerging as a popular discipline in Indian athletics. "In the Olympics, only two [Indians] can go, but at the next World Championships, three can go and be in the finals, and me and Sri can be on the podium. That's what we are aiming for," says Aldrin. First, though, is the Hangzhou Asian Games where Aldrin hopes to achieve two targets with one jump. If he flies past 8.27 m and does so by a distance, he won't just have a medal but also a ticket to his first-ever Olympics. "My main focus will be to not get injured, stay healthy and train well," he says. "If I do this much, I'll be good at the Asian Games."

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